

By Shafi Rahman

National Security Adviser Shiv Shankar Menon was on an unusual mission in the Capital recently. He called on the BJP's Arun Jaitley, leader of the Opposition in the Rajya Sabha, trying to sell the merits of the Civil Liabilities for Nuclear Damages Bill, only to be told that there was not much he could do. Menon also briefed BJP leaders Sushma Swaraj, who is also the leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, and S.S. Ahluwalia but, till now, few appear to be wiser.

Menon's mission explains the current fate of the UPA Government which is fiercely fighting for votes it needs to pass many crucial policy initiatives. Over 50 bills—from the Women's Reservation Bill to the Communal Violence Bill, and the Seed Bill to the Land Acquisition Bill—are stuck in parliamentary quicksand. Without a majority in the Rajya Sabha, the once-cheery UPA is forced to seek help from the Opposition and its own allies. Every tough vote has its arithmetic and the Congress managers are forced to firefight on a Bill-to-Bill basis. The political lines are getting blurred—at times it is BJP plus Left, minus Trinamool, on another it is BJP plus Congress, minus Left. Welcome to a new UPA which deals with the Parliament like a colosseum crowd, baying for blood and brawl, in spite of doubts over its ability to push crucial legislations through.

After coming back to power without having to lean on the Left, Prime Minister Manmohan Singh has been keen on pushing the reform agenda sent to the backburner during his first term. He wants to give a new lease of life to reform bills like the Pension Bill, Land Acquisition Bill, Insurance Bill and Banking Regulatory Bill. The prime minister expected the Nuclear Liability Bill to be passed before he flies to Washington for the Nuclear Security Summit. For Congress President Sonia Gandhi, the Women's Reservation Bill has become an article of faith. Both have been let loose into the numbers game that



Paying for THE BILLS

A large number of pending legislations brings out the UPA Government's failure in convincing its allies as well as the Opposition on key areas of governance

Parliament now looks like.

The haughtiness after the victory in the last Lok Sabha elections is giving way to anxiety, best exemplified in the way the Government tried to bring in the Nuclear Liability Bill. The Bill was set to be introduced in the Lok Sabha during the last session and it was mentioned in the list of business for the day. Sensing the opposition in the House only in the last stretch, the Government developed cold feet. "I

have a request from Minister Prithviraj Chavan that Government does not intend to introduce the Civil Liability for Nuclear Damage Bill on Monday," Lok Sabha Speaker Meira Kumar announced in the House, a rare event in Parliamentary history.

National Democratic Alliance (NDA) Working Chairman L.K. Advani said the Government should tell the House why it was not introducing the Bill since it has been listed, to which